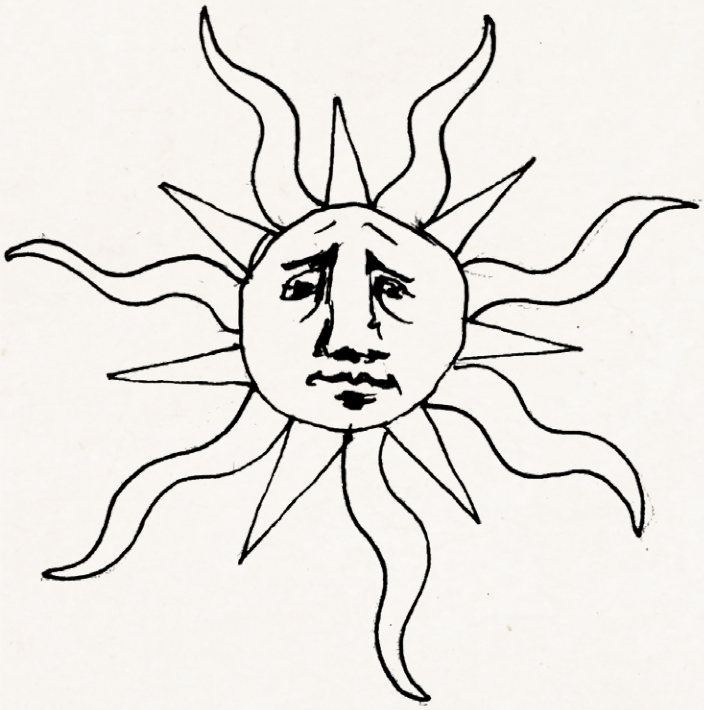
THE DARK DARK AGES

Ontological Speculations in Text and Textile



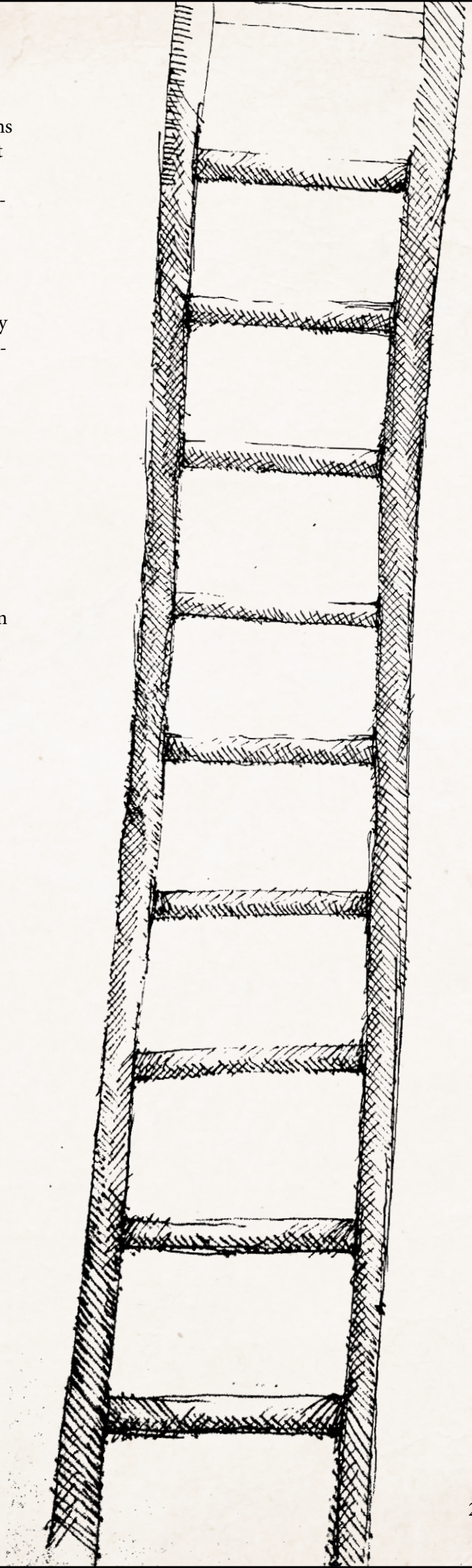
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Abstract

The work *The Dark Dark Ages* consists of textile explorations and a book. A central aspect of the work involves using text and textile as a foundation for formulating and expressing ontological speculations as a kind of alternative historiography. I use the intersection of text and textile as a way to explore concepts such as reason/speculation and truth/myth, but also to reimagine material and materiality.

The title refers to the idea of the Middle Ages as a spiritually and intellectually dark period in our history. This characterization is nowadays considered inaccurate and misleading, which is central to my concept. The project can be said to build on a misunderstanding of history and, from there, attempts to patch together a narrative.

The paper is designed somewhat like a lexicon, with words listed and described. The words loosely follow the alphabetical order – a system that maybe seems well structured and represents a kind of linguistic logic, but which does not necessarily correlate with the world it describes. In the text, I speculate about other perspectives to start from when attempting to describe the world.



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Arrival
At night, before one remembers the words.

One can imagine stepping into a small, unlit room, waiting for night vision to take hold. The animal body must tread carefully, listening through its skin, crouching against the sounds. A gentle movement within the world of materials, the soft imprint of a foot against the ground. Take heed, yield, arrive.

Ascend
Animal
Something that lives and moves, especially at dusk.
Alpha male
Beta male
Sigma male
Ambush
Ancient accident
Annual circle
Arm
The human equivalent of a branch or animal leg.
Armor
Ash
Ancestor
Buried under the house.
Alldeles i Början

Beginning
Birth
Breeding animal
Bridle
Berserk
Bite mark
Braided hair
Blockchain
Bog
Hog
Beast
Body
Bone
Bread
Blight
Bane
Beta male
Broken on the wheel
Bard

Cat
Curse
Calf /Kalv
The little animal. fatted calf.
Det lilla *djuret*. göde-kalven.

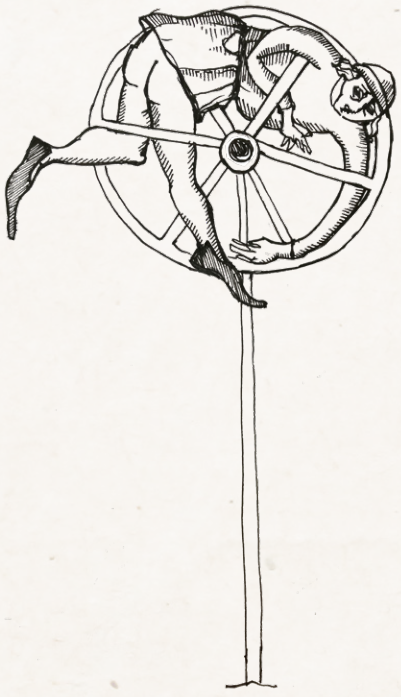
Carrier bag
A container used for storing or putting objects in.

This text, as well as an important aspect of my artistic practice as a whole (see Gatherer), could be likened to a container of some sort. The carrier bag, or the receptacle, is an image I borrow from the book *The Carrier Bag Theory of Fiction* by Ursula K. Le Guin[1]. Her statement that the carrier bag, not the weapon (which is often highlighted in the conventional history writing), was man's first tool has rubbed off on me. That change of focus from the murderous logic of the spear, to the gathering characteristics of man, gives the possibility to write new, more interesting and potentially less violent stories about who we are and why we are here.

The book describes storytelling as a fundamental human trait, just as important as (or even more important than) the ability to hunt down one's prey. But it is also a book about how we, as humans, must liberate ourselves from the dominant killer story, which risks not only destroying itself but taking us humans down with it.

These reflections have led me to wonder whether the story (as a creative force and an event of something coming into existence) is a central aspect of reality, or even that reality itself *is* a story being told.

In an attempt to contribute to such a story, my work has come to develop in a speculative and sometimes ontological direction. Through text and textiles, I allow myself to ponder upon questions regarding "the nature of reality" and "the material realm", without delivering any theoretically or philosophically irrefutable answers.



A person broken on the wheel.

1 Ursula K. Le Guin, *The Carrier Bag Theory of Fiction*, first edition, UK: TJ Books Limited, 2019.

Dim light
Demon
Ditch
Distress
Digital
From Lat. digitus, meaning 'finger' or 'toe' but also 'number'[2].

A word that reveals the body's abstract, mathematical level – the extraordinary code manifesting as jointed stumps at the ends of hands and feet. An early calculating machine. And at the very tips of these stumps, the unique pattern emerges: the fingerprint, the toe mark. One can imagine how the patterned skin of a fingertip is magnified into a topographic map of a vast virtual landscape, where tiny villages emerge, complex lake systems unfold, and digital creatures roam along the edges of low-resolution forests, and above it all, a hyperrealistic aurora borealis shimmers against a sacred, protected sky.

Danger
Dirt
Direction

One can imagine traveling through a landscape in darkness, without any visible landmarks. The body moves almost like an animal's—cautiously. The journey follows the ground, follows time—moving forward in some way, but not in a straight line—rather, a curved one. Without sight or points of reference, one moves in circles. In the darkness, forward becomes a curve backward.



Sun behind clouds.

Dark Ages

The Dark Ages is a historiographical term that has been used to describe a period of cultural decline and intellectual darkness in Europe between the fall of the Roman Empire and approximately the 10th century, the so-called early Middle Ages. The term has been used to emphasize a sense that the Middle Ages was a dark time between two brighter eras in human history; the glory days of antiquity and the Renaissanse, the age of reason and cultural rebirth[3].

In modern historiography, the term "Dark Ages" is avoided as it is considered misleading and inaccurate. However, disregarding the term also risks losing important insights and knowledge—knowledge about light and darkness, about inner and outer reality, and about the qualities of misery.

One can imagine the Dark Ages as something historical—a point on the timeline, a black void in the past, like the round mouth of a nun who's accidentally summoned the wrong kinds of spiritual powers. A time of spiritual harvest failure, lands where the crops do not grow as they should, meatheads moving aimlessly across the packed soil. But the Dark Ages is not only a historical phenomenon, but also an internal one. A complex physiological, mental, and spiritual problem intertwined with the mysterious nature of time. A shadowy era and space within you and the world.

Beyond its relation to the historical Middle Ages, the Inner Dark Ages is also connected to the *Cosmic* Dark Ages. The Cosmic Dark Ages refer to a period of approximately 500 million years in the early universe when all light was enclosed in a dark haze of hydrogen gas[4]. Only when clusters of this hydrogen began collapsing toward their own center of gravity, forming massive stars through pure internal gravitation, could the darkness gradually disperse.

Dimness
Murk
Fog
Smog
Shadow
Skugga
Skygga
Stygga
Stygian darkness
Kimmermörker
Chimeric void
Chivalric obscurity
Riddarnatt
Hjältens mörkerseende
Nattmörker

Natt
Night
Knight

Elevate
Evening
Ether
Energy
Economic man
Earth
Ending

2 Online Etymology Dictionary, *Digital*, https://www.etymonline.com/word/digital, 20 feb, 2025
3 Historiska museet, *Medeltid - när, var, hur?*, https://historiska.se/upptack-historien/artikel/medeltid-nar-var-hur/, 21 feb, 2025
4 Space.com, *What are the Cosmic Dark Ages*, https://www.space.com/what-are-the-cosmic-dark-ages, 5 feb, 2025

E-sport
21st century: E-sports have become bigger than
football, a spiritual athletic development.
Large women in bikinis fight with swords,
you spin around in the office chair, the body glistens.
You're often told that the body with its instincts thinks it
lives on the savannah, amongst the lions
you look at your hands – are they really paws?

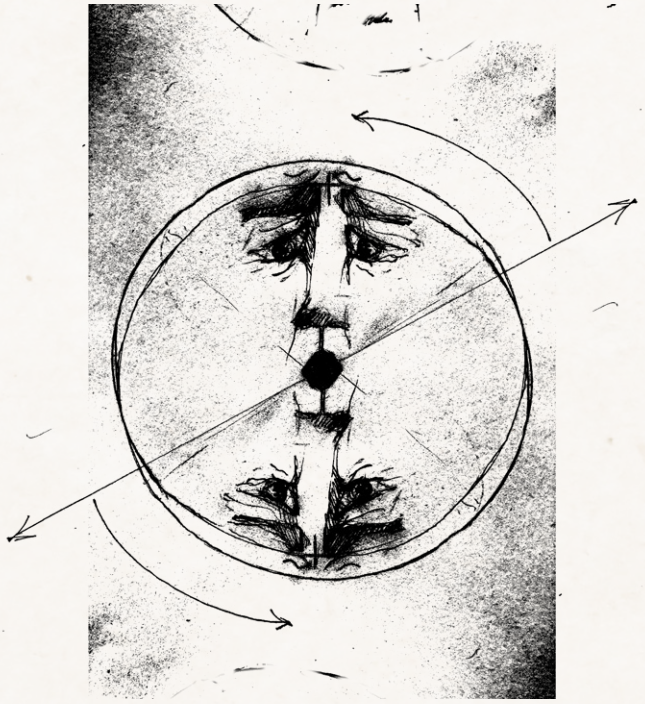
Face
The front of the head / read as a a map.
Farmer
Feather
Feudal lord
Fur
Fortress
Fire
Future
The best has yet to happen.
Fish
Fantom
Fantasy
Felt
A mass of fibers interlocked randomly.

A smooth space with no coordinates or points of reference, kind of like the sea and the steppe where you might lose yourself. Smooth/nomad space and striated/sedentary space is a model or conceptual pair to rethink space.[5] Smooth space and striated space are of different nature but exist only in mixture. A woven fabric can be defined as a striated/sedentary space with its vertical and horizontal elements, its top and bottom and its limitations and boundaries concerning especially the width, which is determined by the frame of the warp. Felt, on the other hand, could be seen as a smooth/nomad space, an anti-fabric "...in principle infinite, open, and unlimited in every direction"[6].

In this project, felt became a way of imagining reality; an unplanned yet complexly composed whole that has the potential to grow in all directions, beyond the logic of the linear(see also Textile Constructions). This suggests that there is no masterplan, the story of reality is being written every moment; fibers tangle further, animalistic and magical.

The felted material is a fiber construction supporting the isolation of body and of sound. The silencing and warming properties of felt are perhaps its most characteristic features and can expand to encompass a kind of spiritual warmth[7]. Insulation can mean the border between inside and outside, tame and wild, safety and danger, sedentism and nomadism. It can mean house, yurt, fur, hair. Insulation relates to hem(home), but also hemlig(secret) or even hemsk(terrible)—words in Swedish that are etymologically connected.

Another aspect of felt is of course the process of making it. To felt is to create a movement that causes the wool fibers to "wander" and entangle. This process can be achieved in various ways, for example, by hand, with the help of a kind horse[8], or with a washing machine. For me, the most crucial aspect of felting lies in the balance between chance and intention. I think that the beauty of the fibers is revealed when I allow the chance to play a role in the process—for instance, by throwing the material into the washing machine and letting the little drum goblin work its magic.



Centrifugal force.

Goblin
Glitter
Grave
Guard
Gnome

5 Gilles Deleuze & Félix Guatarri, *A Thousand Plateaus – Capitalism and Schizophrenia*, London/New York: The Continuum Publishing Company, 2004, p. 523-526.
6 Ibid.
7 Chris Thompson, *Felt: Fluxus, Joseph Beuys and the Dalai Lama*, Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2011. p. 133
8 Youtube, *Mongolian Felt Making,* https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=gJ0uojUHYdA&t=3s, 13 jan, 2025

Guild
Gatherer
Someone who collect several things.

One of my artistic methods involves gathering and putting things together. Text and textiles are my main materials and the activity of collecting/joining closely relates to both linguistic syntax and textile construction techniques such as weaving, sewing, and felting. Components are joined together in a way that creates meaning, whether it is rationally comprehensible or not.

Gap
Gusset
Gum
Gloom
Gods
Gilt
G.O.A.T
Gout
Goat
Laddergoat



A goat appearing in the videogame Call of Juarez: Bound in Blood, 2009. A glitch during a live streamed play session caused the goat to float towards the sky along a ladder leaning against a building. The clip went viral[9].

One might imagine a kind of exchange between the human and the goat; inverted lives, a transaction of light, a transfer in the night.
The soul ascends the ladder,
side by side with a levitating goat,
vertical movement,
a solemn pact between human and animal;
if you float, I float.

The further the work has progressed, the more important the idea of the 'Laddergoat' has become. What if such a seemingly insignificant event as a glitching goat in an old game could turn out to be something absolutely crucial? What if small things matter? Perhaps the event wasn't as random as it seemed, or maybe randomness itself holds significance. What does a levitating goat mean?

The goat is a rather symbolically charged animal, particularly in relation to themes of enlightenment, knowledge, light, and darkness. The biblical scapegoat sent into the wilds, the Greek god Pan, who 'stirs insatiable desires and panic in the wilderness of the mind,'[10]and of course Satan, are three well-known examples. Another famous goat figure is Eliphas Lévi's Baphomet, which can be understood partially as a representation of the equilibrium of opposites[11]. Like the ladder, Baphomet points both upward and downward.

Hair
Horse
Historical beast that doesn't fit in with the present day.

A sweaty draft animal from the past, shuffling with its hooves across dry land. The horse is nature, the rider is a sluggish thought. Horsehair consists of long, coarse strands from the horse's mane and tail, it is well-suited for horsehair shirts[12].

Hay
Hunting



Person hunted by a beast.

High Value Woman
Hair Braid

When braiding hair, three strands are joined together in a diagonal overlapping pattern. The three strands represent the three fundamental elements that the universe consisted of during its first minutes after the Big Bang: hydrogen, helium, and lithium.[13] Since then, a large number of elements have been formed in stars and laboratories, collectively composing a complex universe. The braid's three strands or elements, along with the hands that perform the braiding, illustrate how the act of joining, the movement itself, is crucial to how something comes into being. It is the relationship between the parts, rather than the parts themselves, that constitutes our reality.

The hair braid is both matter and a symbol of an underlying principle; it simultaneously consists of hair and the universe's three initial elements. You could therefore approach your own hair as something that is, at the same time, three minutes from the Big Bang *and* a sort of modern head-fur.

Harness
Hawk
Hoovering
Hooves
Hands
Heel
Häl
Häll
Hell
Help

9 Know Your Meme, *Laddergoat*, https://knowyourmeme.com/memes/laddergoat, 12 feb, 2025.
10 The archive for Research in Archetypal Symbolism, *Goat*, Book of symbols, Kathleen Martin, Köln: Taschen, 2010, p. 320.
11 Julian Strube, "The 'Baphomet' of Eliphas Lévi: Its Meaning and Historical Context.", Correspondences, 4, 2017, p. 39.
12 A shirt made of horsehair, chafing and irritating the wearer's skin—a way to remind oneself of sin and penance. Handwovenmagazine, *The History of Hairshirts,* https://handwovenmagazine.com/history-hairshirts/, 1 march, 2025.
13 Michigan State University, *In the beginning there were three elements*, https://msutoday.msu.edu/news/2014/in-the-beginning-there-were-three-elements, 23 feb, 2025.

History Writing
The writing of History.

It is timely to problematize conventional history, but perhaps the entire historiographic project itself – the attempt to write down history along a timeline that stretches linearly backward – is a peculiar mission, especially when it comes to the history of pre-modern perceptions of reality. Historiography could be viewed as an "intellectual and cultural construct, one particular way of construing and constructing the past; at once a tradition of reasoning, a way of being, and a certain practice of subjectivity. The desire to write history is specific to certain people (societies, classes) and not others. It is connected to some phenomena- the emergence of the modern state, progress, scientific rationality- and not others, which it usually defines itself against (magic, gods)."[14].

This view challenges the phenomenon of anachronism and the Western historiography's belief in its ability to avoid it. Modern Western historiography itself can be understood as a project that inevitably will be characterized by the anachronistic when dealing with pre-modern or non-western history, since the knowledge from which it is written is not continuous with the knowledge of the history being studied.

With that said, this work does not really deal with historical events or historiography as a social science topic, at least not on any deeper level. The historical past functions more as a loose backdrop for thoughts about our present time and questions about *being* itself. Historical records are not treated as more true or informative about our past than fantasy books, movies, and video games. In this work, 'the past' is not considered as something exclusively historical, but also something *inner,* entangled with imagination and misunderstandings.

Iron
Insect

Loon
Longing
Light
Ladder
Vertical Polarity: basement/attic, earth/sky, roots/crown, body/soul.

One adjusts the eyes in a direction, aiming light upward, a plumb line to follow with feet, with paws. *Hooves treading headwinds, clockwise*. The ladder is a kind of spine, with its tiny vertebrae as ladder rungs, inward, upward.

The ladder is what joins that which is above with that which is below. We need it in order to travel between different levels of reality.

Mouth
Mare
Material
The matter from which a thing is or can be made.

My main working materials in this project are text and textile. Both concern the hands and the imagination, time and listening. You sit at the worktable with the letters scattered in front of you, or the threads, the wool, the rags. You pick up some old word or scrap of fabric and try to see it anew, almost as if it was a person; a nonhuman body "not restricted to passive intractability" but also including "the ability to make things happen, to produce effects."[15]. In an attempt not only to avoid further harm to the planet, but also to deepen my own relationship with the external reality, I practice cultivating a kind of respect for the materials that surround me, including torn fabrics, overused words, and pixelated images from some old video game. I try to not view the material as dead, empty or passive, but instead find a different approach and language, something that to some extent perhaps could be compared to a "grammar of animacy"[16]. At least I recognize from my own work the attempt to adopt a perspective where human and non-human materials and bodies can be explored non-hierarchically.

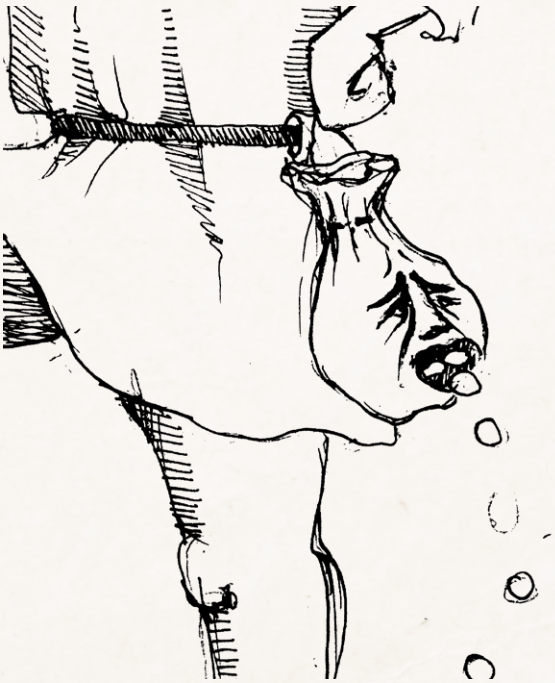
Since video game aesthetics and parts of the digital sphere are also important aspects of my working materials I would like to add a few words about them here as well. First I need to state the link between the digital and the body which, just as text and textile, concerns the hands (see Digital). Furthermore, there is a significant connection between the textile and the digital, particularly in their shared basic element—the stitch/pixel—which can form patterns on grids such as in embroidery, knitting, and weaving, or be interpreted as computer graphics[17]. It seems, then, that the organized space of the grid is what primarily connects the textile and the digital. However, just as felt could be considered more of a 'smooth space' compared to embroidery, knitting, or weaving, there are probably aspects of digital reality that could also be viewed this way—for example hot, dead or glitching pixels, or the open-world games which non-linear game design allows the player to move freely and visit any location at any time. In my work, I try to regard the digital image as a material equivalent to text and textile. The "grammar of animacy" doesn't have to be limited to the physical reality but can also include the virtual, especially since the boundary between them is anything but clear.

Mythology
Morrow
Museum

Night

14 Sanjay Seth, "Which Past? Whose Transcendental Presupposition?", Postcolonial Studies, Vol. 11, No. 2, 2008, p.215, 223.
15 Jane Bennett, *Vibrant Matter; A Political Ecology of Things,* p. 5, Durham and London, Duke University Press, 2010..
16 Robin Wall Kimmerer, *Braiding Sweetgrass,* UK: Penguin Random House, 2020, p. 55.
17 Klara Bothén, *The invocation of X: Passing on a textile Code*, Masters thesis, Academy of Arts and Design, Gothenburg University, 2019, p. 38.

Ode
Owl
Opening
Organs
Outer soil
One can imagine kneeling on the damp ground. Digging slightly into the soil, pressing down a finger as if it were a short wand. The wrong kind of magic accidentally seeps out.



Pouch with money.

Pouch
Pearl
Plague
Paradox
Post truth
An adjective "relating to or denoting circumstances in which objective facts are less influential in shaping public opinion than appeals to emotion and personal belief"[18] or *a "political subordination of reality"*[19].

Considering the term The Dark Ages today, in 2025, it is tempting to connect it to the development of a 'post-truth society,' science denial, and conspiracy theories. Listening only to that which confirms one's own worldview and refusing to tolerate being proven wrong or to remain in uncertainty could be viewed as a kind of contemporary 'dark age' thinking[20]. It could be argued that "*political ideology is doing to social science what religious ideology did to natural science round about the time of Galileo*"[21], referring to the massive resistance that Galileo's ideas faced from religious authorities.

A current example is, of course, the increasing climate change denial and its connection to the rise of right-wing nationalism in Europe[22], which is putting the world and all its inhabitants at risk. It's dark indeed. It is close at hand to compare the development of anti-democratic forces and growing class gaps with the middle age feudalism and hierarchical worldview.

In my work, societal processes as described above are one aspect of my use of *The Dark Ages*. It's a kind of political darkness that we have to confront in this world. However, my use of the expression go beyond a strictly political definition. I aim to make it encompass understandings and experiences of darkness (and light) that are bound to both inner and outer reality.

Pendulum
Pig

Quest

Rot
Riding School
Relationality
Reason
What separates us from animals. Or what places us right in the dense mystery of the animal kingdom.

As previously mentioned, the term the Dark Ages originates from a perception of the period as one marked by cultural decline, superstition, and intellectual darkness. Darkness is associated with ignorance and spiritual obscurity. The dualistic division reinforces this image by separating body and soul—naturally placing the light of reason within the soul's domain, while the body belongs to the material, the animalistic, and the earthly. Dualism and binary polarities often appear in my work as something to question and push against in one direction or another.

Another model for understanding reason might be described like this: *"Reason is not disembodied, as the tradition has largely held, but arises from the nature of our brains, bodies, and bodily experience. This is not just the innocuous and obvious claim that we need a body to reason; rather, it is the striking claim that the very structure of reason itself comes from the details of our embodiment."*[23] Such a description acknowledges the body's capacities to a greater extent and perhaps makes it more interesting to study. What are we really made of, and where do we belong? Recognizing our kinship with animals becomes essential: *"Reason is thus not an essence that separates us from other animals; rather, it places us on a continuum with them."*[24]

18 Oxford Languages, *word of the year/2016*, https://languages.oup.com/word-of-the-year/2016/, 20 jan, 2025.
19 Richard Marshall & Lee McIntyre, (2021) *Science denial, post-truth and our new dark age*. Journal of Philosophy of Education, 55:829–836. https://doi.org/10.1111/1467-9752.12618
20 Ibid.
21 Ibid.
22 Chalmers Tekniska Högskola, *Climate change denial strongly linked to right-wing nationalism,* https://www.chalmers.se/en/current/news/tme-climate-change-denial-strongly-linked-to-right-wing-nationalism/ , 19 jan, 2025
23 George Lakoff & Mark Johnson, *Philosophy In The Flesh: The embodied mind and its challenge to Western thought*, New York: Basic Books, 1999, p.3-4.
24 Ibid.

In my work, I play with both the 'enlightened' and the 'unenlightened' position. The former is expressed through a use of the "grammar of science," such as museum display boxes, excel documents, and the alphabetical order. The latter is reflected in the contents of the boxes and texts, which often have a more elusive or ambiguous character. Placing the work within the 'Dark Ages' has allowed me to not constantly seek clarity and comprehensibility, but instead remain in a state of confusion and ignorance. The materials speak in their peculiar ways, not primarily through reason but rather through intuition, touch, smell and so on.

Sheep
Spear
Spindle
Stone
Star
Shadow

Lack of Light.

Many knights have moved out into the manosphere. You can imagine rooms where broad-legged men gather in digital armchairs. They practice how to carry themselves and how to court the ladies). They discuss in groups, training their voices and posture and move sideways in the outskirts of the internet, for it is a virtue to never show ones back.

The back belongs to the unconscious side of the body. We can only see it through reflection, meaning someone else's position and gaze, never our own. We try to control the back through training, butt lifts and shaving off the back fat, but it's unfortunately like scraping the top off an iceberg. The unconscious side of the body communicates with the unconscious sides of other bodies. One could say they converse with each other without the oversight of consciousness.

Seam
Sphere
Stick
Success
Skincare
Sun (old sun, new light)
Stretch

One can imagine that the thought somehow became elastic. That it changed in its very constitution to a stretchy pair of tights that managed to encompass and clothe the unthinkable. And that the eyes could perceive something where there had previously only been darkness. Visions bending over sharp crests.

"What if the poetics of cloth were composed of 'soft logics', modes of thought that twist and turn and stretch and fold? And in this movement new encounters were made, beyond the constraint of binaries? The binary offers two possibilities, 'either/or'; 'soft logics' offer multiple possibilities. They are the realm of 'and/and', where anything can happen." [25]

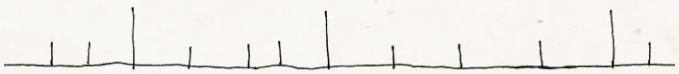
25 Pennina Barnett "Folds, fragments, surfaces: towards a poetics of cloth" in The Textile Reader, London, Berg Publishers, 2012, p.183.

Tissue
Tear
Tactile
Tooth
Tongue
Tail
Tale
Tent
Temple
Tomb
Time

Something that moves in peculiar patterns,

- The *linear* time: a series of events one after the other, a row of teeth in a gum.
- The *circular* time: a wheel on a cart pulled by some old animal.

Then there is the *irregular* time:
the one that seems to well up completely disordered, unplanned, shifting, prying, arching. The time that can arise when you find yourself using the word *fair damsel* instead of *attractive woman*, old-fashioned, a kind of confusion for yourself and the years that have passed, the years that passed long before you were born. A confusion about the fact that there was a world before yourself got there and that you just ended up somewhere, in a line of others.



Linear time.

Textile Time

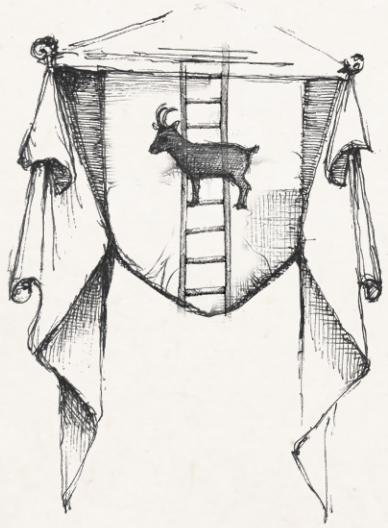
Textiles have historically been made from natural fibers which easily decompose. Up until the invention of synthetic fibers made from fossil materials that never decay, textile was probably the perfect metaphor for the eternal cycle of building up and breaking down. A construction and a system of fibers and threads where both architectural and philosophical elements are embedded, eventually decaying into new soil for new plants to build from. Textile utility- and art objects had the simultaneously terrifying and liberating quality of rotting without leaving any traces, to simply die and to merge into the nothingness of the past and then at the most end up in the memory world or the immaterial reality where the mind runs around like a horse. The synthetic petroleum based fiber has other qualities, perhaps it speaks of the attempts to refute the circular time and the wish for eternal life, since it can

never disappear.

Due to decomposition, old textiles displayed in museums are almost always fragmented in one way or another. There is never a full picture, never a complete truth. Perhaps one could therefore say that the history of textile, as technology and as material culture, is to a large extent placed in the speculative realm rather than the archeological. That is an appealing aspect of this material; the unknown and the position of questioning it allows you to take.

Tide
Tree
Träd
Token
Totem
Tiger
Texture
Textile Constructions

In my work, I return to weaving and felting as two constructions and techniques that represent different processes in our reality. The plain weave is generally used to describe space and time according to the theory of relativity. The spacetime weave stretches over the universe and curves close to heavy bodies, causing time to slow down[26]. The weave or net is also used to visualize social connections and relations. The woven structure is clear and predictable. The felted structure on the other hand, has an irregular and unpredictable character. It is a fiber construction supporting isolation of body and of sound. A warm and silent (and yet quite chaotic) material of reality. But also an example of an irreversible process where fibers, once they're interlocked, can never untangle.This process of fibers being felted together tighter and tighter, could be a way of describing the complexity of global networks or interhuman intrigue in a more dynamic way than, i.e, the metaphor of the regularized weave can offer.[27]



Coat of arms / face.

Text

In the part of the exam project that is materialised through a text I have tried to write with focus on the body and its experiences of the material and the virtual world. Hair/fur, skin, hands, and feet are receivers of signals and information, and I have tried to remain in that state where such sensory input has not yet reached the organizing activity of consciousness. Perhaps one could say that I have tried to think and write like a piece of felted wool. To venture into a murky syntax of chaotic fibers and let tiny tiny fragments meet and interlock. Insignificant details, blurry mental images and any boring observation at all can be connected and given meaning.

This connection between language and felt is also in a way related to the latin word texere which is the root to both text and textile and means 'to weave, to plait, to construct'. But if the commonality of the weave, the braid, and the construction is a kind of ordered system for parts to be joined together, perhaps the felted textile represents a more unordered system – another kind of text. The word felt stems from the Proto-Germanic *felt* which means *'to beat'* and from Medieval Latin *filtrum*, felt *'used to strain impurities from liquid'*. Felting can thus be understood as a process of beating and filtering, of violence and purification. But also as a process of complex and random entanglement.

Unique Selling Point
Udder

View
Vixen
Veil

A curtain has been drawn. The veil of reason. One stands on the wrong side, in a dim, drafty vestibule. Looking down at one's chapped hands. Whose hands are these? Then, stepping out onto the porch again, looking up at the night sky. A red dwarf struggles and flickers with its light, a pitiful sight. Reaching one's arms toward it—are these your hands I have been given?

Water
Winter
Warning
Whisper
Wait
Wand
Weather
Wimple
Wailing
Workhorse
Will-o'-the-wisp
Window

Utblick mot vildheten/
outlook towards the wilderness

26 Live science, *Space-time,* https://www.livescience.com/space-time.html, 28 feb, 2025.

27 Chris Thompson, *Felt: Fluxus, Joseph Beuys and the Dalai Lama*, Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2011.

Words

A single unit of language

I appreciate words. This text and important parts of my masters project as a whole is built on the emphasis on specific words. Importance is placed on the singular objects or components of the reality being described. I think this is how I learned about language and reality in primary school; that there is one physical reality and that we put words on everything in it as a part of a process of understanding it. Historically and in a Western dominant culture context, written text has been privileged as the primary means of preserving and transmitting knowledge. We trust the written word even when our bodies feel differently or when the material culture suggests another story. We know a thing through its name. The problem is that the emphasis on singular nouns can have a fragmenting effect, as if the objects are detached from their context, causing reality to become scattered. One's own body, for example, can feel like a separate entity, a slippery soap floating in space, disconnected from the rest of the world.

Shawn Wilson suggests another perspective that arises from the ontology and language belonging to his people, the Cree, namely that "...an object or thing is not as important as one's relationships to it."[28] and that the "...reality is not an object but a process of relationships."[29]. I think that description aligns with the feeling that can arise in relation to an artistic material or object, where one strives for a kind of respect and sensitivity toward it (in other words, a good relationship), in order to be ready to follow the direction it wants to take.

Yodeler

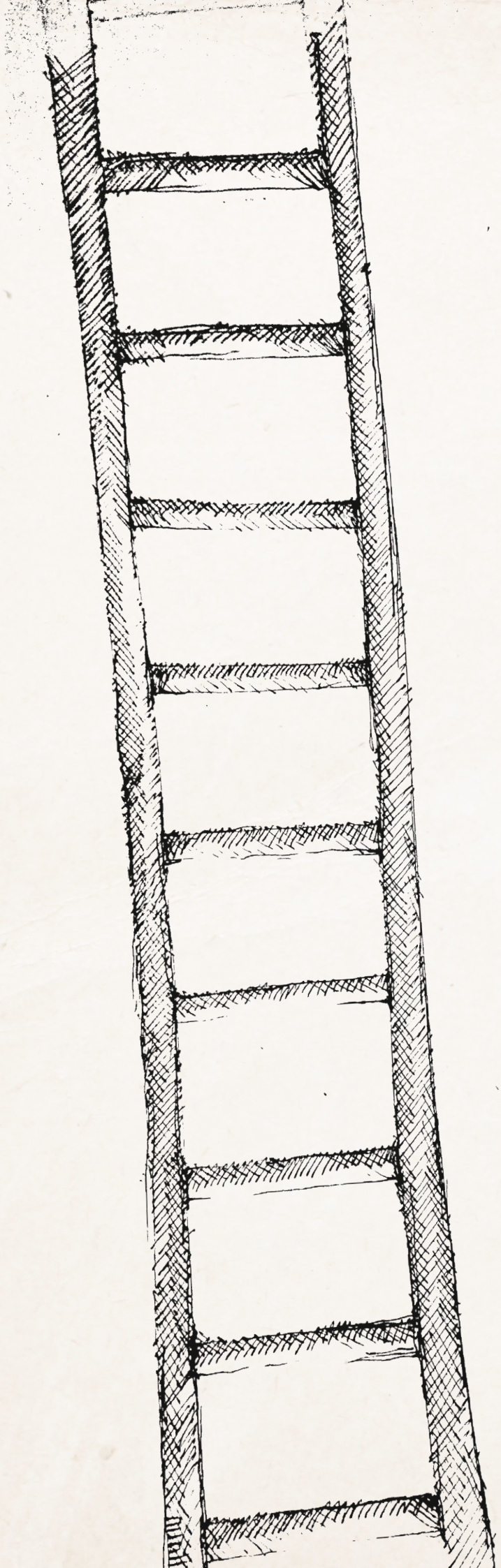
Åker

Älva

Örn

28 Shawn Wilson, Research Is Ceremony – Indigenous Research Methods, Canada: Fernwood Publishing, 2008, p.73.

29 Ibid.



Reflection/Reflexion/ —-> (Departure)
The action of throwing back light / To bend back.
/A sudden flashing glitch in the fabric of the universe.

In the beginning of this essay (see Carrier Bag), I posed the question whether one could describe reality as a story being told. This could either mean that one or several gods, forces, or principles are holding the pen or the shuttle, weaving our world with words or threads in real time. We living beings would either exist within their consciousness or be some kind of material extension of them. Another possible idea could be that reality doesn't have an author but is constantly being read and interpreted — like a story, by everyone in it. In both cases, the idea of *the glitch* is an interesting phenomenon. It's either a sudden short-circuit in the gods' imagination — a temporary brain melt or weaving error. Or it's something in our reality that we fail to read and interpret in a meaningful way. Something that doesn't fit within a certain box. We perceive the glitch as sudden, faulty, and random. One visitor told a story about our mutual friend's mother who once "glitched" and ate a fly.

During the examination and exhibition of my work, many conversations revolved around the elusive nature of truth, how the very idea of truth feels unstable or outdated in our time, and also how difficult it is to escape various dualistic categories and divisions of our reality. Especially the latter led me to realize I need to take a closer look at the concept of *natureculture*, coined by Donna Haraway, as well as the so-called *new materialist thinking*, an area I had already touched on while writing the essay, but without really being aware of it in any deeper sense. In addition to textile materials and techniques serving as analogies or representations of something beyond themselves, the goat and the ladder have also become increasingly important images in my work — tools for trying to understand reality and connect its scattered polarities. 'The laddergoat' meme, as a glitch and a material-discursive entity, can be seen as a figure that encapsulates many branching ideas about nature, culture, the material, the virtual, and potentially spiritual reality. For some visitors 'The laddergoat' was also a personal throwback to their teenage years in front of early Youtube.

A valid critique I got during the examination was that I could've gone further in questioning 'the grammar of knowledge' in the way I installed my work, and that the tacit knowledge of textile craft could be more manifested. I've been reminded of the power of materiality as a language, and I take with me the call to let it speak for itself. I realize that text — perhaps because of its privileged position in our culture — easily drowns out the silent, sensory expressions of a material, making it even more relevant for me to explore this relationship further. I will continue to investigate the contemplative space that has emerged in my practice through the interplay of text and textile — a space where speculation, possibility, and dreaming are given room alongside the longing for truth.

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